In November 1952, the Praja Parishad leader, Prem Nath Dogra, and one of his close associates, Sham Lal Sharma, were detained on the orders of Abdullah's interim government. In the spring of 1953, the situation in Jammu grew tense, with the Praja Parishad *satyagraha*. The Abdullah regime retaliated with considerable violence, dispersing crowds with police *lathi* charge and numerous arrests. Dr Mookerjee helped organise this agitation and in May 1953, he set out for Jammu where he proposed to investigate the situation. He was arrested at the state border by the Jammu and Kashmir state police that reported to Abdullah. Mookerjee was taken to Srinagar where, on 23 June 1953, he died under detention. His demise attracted wide publicity in India where the affairs of Jammu and Kashmir always managed to become the subject of public debate. It was widely believed that he had been murdered.

Abdullah's controversial role in Mookerjee's death was being scrutinised with increasing anxiety by the Government of India. The Director IB B. N. Mullick believed that Mookerjee's death, whatever its causes, was the last straw and demanded intervention. Karan Singh and D. P. Dhar, a young member of Abdullah's administration, teamed up with Abdullah's deputy, Bakshi Ghulam Mohammed and decided to bring the crisis to an end by removing Abdullah from power.

By now, Nehru who had earlier called on Sheikh Abdullah in Srinagar in May 1953, had concluded that his old friend was out of control. Abdullah had repudiated the tailor-made 1952 Delhi Accord and was insisting on a status for the state that could only lead to secession from India. Nehru did not oppose the plan to depose Abdullah, nor did Maulana Abul Kalam Azad, who had also visited Sheikh Abdullah in Srinagar in July 1953.

Was Sheikh Abdullah really working for the independence of his state as Nehru earlier believed? B. N. Mullick was probably nearer to the truth when he observed that Abdullah was not actually planning to take the state into Pakistan, but was looking for a semi-independent status where the Indian Government would protect him while he would benefit economically from the tourism industry and other sources, free from the interference of the Hindu-dominated government in New Delhi.